SPORTS

# KNIGHTS OF THE ARENA

**World chess champion D. Gukesh and para archer Sheetal Devi are new favourites, as cricket's top stars retain their positions amongst both men and women. Sindhu and Neeraj, too, head their respective lists by long margins**

*By* SUHANI SINGH

**Two 17-year-olds captivated Indian sport last year** and both have made their debut in the India Today Mood of the Nation Poll. Para archer Sheetal Devi may not have bagged an Olympic medal but her heroics won hearts in Paris after her very first arrow, fired from her legs, scored a bull's eye. In April 2024, D. Gukesh became the youngest winner of Candidates, the tournament which decides the challenger to the world champion. By December 16, he became the game's youngest world champion. While Sheetal broke new ground as the first para athlete to debut in the female sportspersons list, Gukesh entered straight at No. 3 in the male field. The teens show that the future of Indian sport is in safe hands.

Among female sportspersons, P.V. Sindhu, the de facto number one, is followed by double Olympics bronze winner Manu Bhaker (No. 2)

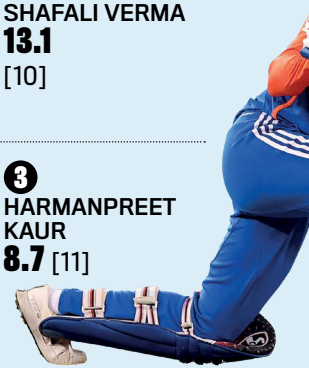
## Q. Who is India's No. 1 female cricketer?



2 SHAFALI VERMA
**13.1** [10]



3 HARMANPREET KAUR
**8.7** [11]



*All figures in %; rest, others & don't know/ can't say (DK/ CS); Feb. '25 figures in bold, Aug. '24 in [ ]*




1 VIRAT KOHLI
**39.4** [39.3]

PTI

## Q. Who is India's No. 1 male cricketer?



2 M.S. DHONI
**22.3** [29.6]



4 SHUBMAN GILL
**8** [1.5]



3 ROHIT SHARMA
**11.2** [11.9]



5 SURYAKUMAR YADAV
*Bihar*
**3.2** [3.3]